

Chapter 43-1

For a moment, the atmosphere was at a standstill.

After a long while, Bai Weiwei smiled bitterly, "So you're still standing on Liang Shi's side, aren't you? For her sake, you can give up anything."

"No." Xu Qingzhu took a deep breath, forcing herself to regain composure, "This isn't about what I want or don't want. You're asking me to trade someone else's interests with you."

"But you could just make the trade!" Bai Weiwei questioned her, "Isn't Minghui Jewelry very important to you? You've wanted to join the company since you were in school, you wanted to make a career, you wanted to restore it to its former glory. Look how capable you are now—you've already attracted attention as soon as you started, you're so close to your goal. Don't you want it?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled helplessly, "Of course I want it, but that doesn't mean I'll trade away Liang Shi's things for it."

"Then what can you trade with me?" Bai Weiwei asked.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her.

Their eyes met, and Bai Weiwei was the first to look away. She asked with a choked voice, "What else do you have to trade with me?"

"Let's trade with our years of friendship." Xu Qingzhu laughed coldly. Even though tears had already formed in her eyes, she still forced a smile, one even gentler than usual, "If you have that video, then you know I didn't deliberately hurt Chen Liuying—I was acting in self-defense."

Bai Weiwei's expression changed, but she immediately said, "You're talking nonsense."

"Whether I'm talking nonsense or not, you know best!" Xu Qingzhu glared at her, her gaze instantly sharp, "Weiwei, I truly considered you a friend. All those years between us can't be fake, but they can't compare to this one year with Chen Liuying?"

Bai Weiwei was momentarily speechless.

While she was organizing her words, Xu Qingzhu said coldly, "If you insist on releasing that video, then I'll also give you a gift."

Bai Weiwei frowned, "What?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't say. She just lowered her head, took out her phone, and called Sally, "Where are you two? Come in for a moment."

Almost as soon as she hung up, Sally and Lin Luoxi walked in.

Lin Luoxi even closed the restroom door and placed a "Under Maintenance" barrier outside.

The space, which wasn't small to begin with, suddenly became crowded.

When Bai Weiwei saw them, she laughed coldly, "So you're planning to use numbers to bully the few?"

"We're nowhere near that yet." Xu Qingzhu said, "Don't Chen Liuying's fans outnumber any of ours? You said you'd post the video online, but I didn't say you were bullying me."

"So you want to have a falling out with me?" Bai Weiwei was shocked.

Lin Luoxi couldn't stand listening anymore and clicked her tongue from the side, saying to Sally, "Do you smell something?"

Sally, who always cooperated seamlessly with her in such matters, asked, "Flower scent?"

"Mm." Lin Luoxi smiled, "What a big white lotus flower¹."

Bai Weiwei glared at her, "Lin Luoxi, stop being so passive-aggressive."

"Did I call you by name?" Lin Luoxi stood there with her arms crossed, looking at her with contempt, then glanced at Chen Liuying's face, "Maybe I was talking about the one next to you?"

Chen Liuying raised her head and met her gaze.

After a moment, she looked away without saying anything.

"See that, Bai Weiwei?" Lin Luoxi said, "You're the only one who's stupid."

"Lin Luoxi!" Bai Weiwei clenched her fists, "This is between me and Xu Qingzhu. Don't interfere."

Then she looked at Xu Qingzhu, "What do you want to say? Continue."

Xu Qingzhu said, "Show me your video."

Bai Weiwei: "..."

"What are you doing? Want to destroy the evidence?" Bai Weiwei accused angrily, "I already said, you just need to make Liang Shi give up that role and it'll be fine."

"As far as I know, the audition results aren't out yet. Why are you saying this? Do you know some inside information, or do you have no confidence in Chen Liuying?"

Xu Qingzhu had completely calmed down by now, her aura fully unleashed, her voice cold, her gaze fixed tightly on Bai Weiwei. Even though her heart was reluctant, she knew that reaching this point was no accident—she could only make a decisive cut.

Bai Weiwei was pressured by her aura into taking half a step back, but still tried to save face, "How could I not have confidence in Chen Liuying? If it weren't for Liang Shi getting connections with Zhao Ying, I wouldn't even consider her worth my attention."

"Then do you think Zhao Ying would support just anyone?" Xu Qingzhu continued questioning.

"That's all because of Zhao Xuning!" Bai Weiwei said the name through gritted teeth, then continued, "And besides, she's the third young miss of the Liang family—which production crew wouldn't want her? Having her means a walking haute couture² manufacturing machine, a topic queen. This drama will be popular before it even airs. Isn't she just constantly using her privileges? I'm just asking her to give up something that didn't belong to her in the first place."

"What belongs to her? What doesn't belong to her?" Xu Qingzhu's voice wasn't loud, but it carried extraordinary pressure, especially those cold eyes that no longer held any of their usual gentleness or affection, "Do you really think there's nothing sordid about your way of thinking?"

Bai Weiwei was suddenly scolded and became furious, "You!"

"What you should be doing now is improving Chen Liuying's acting skills, not using underhanded tactics to pressure me here." Xu Qingzhu said, "Everyone knows Chen Liuying's acting isn't good. What's so glorious about being better than her?"

Chen Liuying finally couldn't help but speak up, "Xu Qingzhu, that's quite hurtful to say."

"I can be even more hurtful." Xu Qingzhu glared at her, then said, "But weren't you the ones who hurt people first?"

"Post that video of yours if you want." Xu Qingzhu said, "I don't care, but asking Liang Shi to give up her role is im-pos-si-ble!"

Bai Weiwei was confused, "Why? Do you love her that much?"

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, "Bai Weiwei, I should be asking you why. Is it because of that incident at Huayue International³ that you became like this? Did I not try to save you? That day I was called over by your message—I was the most innocent victim."

"You went to Huayue International to negotiate resources for Chen Liuying. I got implicated because of you, and I never said anything about it, did I? I considered you a friend, I wanted to comfort you, but what about you?" Xu Qingzhu laughed coldly, "Did you become unscrupulous for Chen Liuying's sake, or were you always like this—I just never saw your true nature?"

A tear fell from Bai Weiwei's eyes.

She was angry at first, then became expressionless, and after a while, she laughed coldly. When she finished laughing, she said, "Oh my, I'm really so moved. Xu Qingzhu, you consider me such a good friend that you won't listen to anything I say, and instead want to dictate my life. Why do you always act so high and mighty? It makes me sick, you know?"

"Why did I go to Huayue International to negotiate? Because that was part of my job!" Bai Weiwei scoffed, "If you really considered me a friend, how could you not know what my job entailed? How could you have that expression every time I mentioned Liang Shi?"

"You don't tell me things, I can't tell you my troubles. When I hit walls at work, when I drank until I threw up trying to secure resources again and again, what were you doing? You were busy preparing for your wedding with Liang Shi, you were busy being lovey-dovey with Liang Shi. Did you ever care about me? Are we even friends?! Is this how you treat me as a friend?"

By the end, her emotions had completely broken down.

But Xu Qingzhu gradually calmed down.

She was like an outsider observing all of this, observing Bai Weiwei's breakdown and hysteria.

Footnotes:

¹ White lotus flower: Chinese internet slang referring to someone who appears pure and innocent on the surface but is actually manipulative or scheming

² Haute couture: High-end, custom-made fashion design

³ Huayue International: A company name mentioned in the story's context

Chapter 43-2

After a long while.

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes, and when she opened them again, there was complete clarity.

Her voice wasn't loud, her pace unhurried as she said gently, "Yes, I'm not a qualified friend."

After saying this, she smiled lightly, but with a hint of mockery, then looked at Bai Weiwei, meeting her gaze directly, and said with particular sincerity: "When you hit walls at work and needed comfort, when you needed someone to pick you up after drinking until you threw up trying to secure resources, I wasn't there.

"Because I was busy—I was busy with arranged marriage, busy marrying Liang Shi to fill Minghui's financial holes, I was busy being looked down upon by the Liang family, worried about Minghui going bankrupt. I was too busy, so busy I didn't dare tell you."

Xu Qingzhu's voice lowered, "Mm, we can't be friends anymore."

Her mood was heavy, and she didn't want to argue further with Bai Weiwei, "For the sake of our friendship, I only hope you can open your eyes and stop picking girlfriends from the trash."

"What about you? Didn't you also marry Liang Shi?" Bai Weiwei said, "And you still defend her so much!"

"I chose Liang Shi, not to compete with you over who's worse." Xu Qingzhu scoffed, "Even compared to the old Liang Shi, Chen Liuying is still trash."

Chen Liuying: "..."

"Damn." Chen Liuying got angry, "What do you mean?"

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her, her voice extremely indifferent, "Exactly what it sounds like."

Then Xu Qingzhu said, "If you want to release that video, go ahead."

After saying this, she had Lin Luoxi open the door and walked straight out.

But before leaving, she still gave Bai Weiwei a piece of advice: "Learn to be a decent person."

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After coming out of the restroom, walking through the bright shopping mall.

Not long after, Xu Qingzhu heard wailing cries coming from the restroom.

Her heart clenched, but she still laughed it off.

Cherry rolled her eyes, "She's really good at playing innocent."

Sally also found it incredible, "To think I used to find junior Weiwei straightforward and cheerful."

Cherry: "Don't insult those two words."

Xu Qingzhu kept her hands in her coat pockets and didn't join their conversation.

But Cherry asked her, "What video? Did you hit Chen Liuying?"

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow, "How did you know?"

"I guessed." Cherry said, "She seems quite scheming."

Xu Qingzhu smiled slightly, "Pretty much. I pushed her."

Cherry paused, thought for a few seconds, then suddenly said, "Did she sexually harass you?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She hadn't expected Cherry's logical reasoning ability to be so strong.

Xu Qingzhu changed the subject, "Do you often play murder mystery games¹?"

"Occasionally." Cherry said, "My luck is too good—I often don't get the murderer role, so it's boring and I stopped going."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

But seeing that Xu Qingzhu was changing the subject, Cherry knew this matter was pretty much confirmed.

She cursed under her breath, "Fuck! I really don't know what Bai Weiwei sees in her. So young, yet blind and foolish."

"Do you have a way to deal with this?" Cherry asked, "They're desperate now and capable of anything. What if they really buy trending topics to smear you?"

"I recorded it." Xu Qingzhu looked back at the restroom, shrugged and said, "I hope she'll still leave herself some room for retreat."

When Chen Liuying approached, Xu Qingzhu had pressed the record button.

So all of Chen Liuying's words were in her phone. She had originally wanted to play it for Bai Weiwei and discuss deleting it together.

But Bai Weiwei's attitude broke her heart too much.

So she kept this last trump card, hoping she wouldn't need to use it in the future.

Footnotes:

¹ Murder mystery games: Popular social deduction games where players are assigned roles (including murderers) and must solve crimes through discussion and reasoning

Chapter 43-3

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Xu Qingzhu was in a bad mood and was too lazy to continue shopping in the afternoon. Cherry had something at home and left early.

Sally wanted to go dancing and insisted on dragging Xu Qingzhu along, but Xu Qingzhu politely declined.

In the end, Sally had to go alone.

Xu Qingzhu went to another mall to look at the current jewelry designs on the market.

BARE also made jewelry, but it wasn't their main focus - they were more into clothes and bags. In the industry, Minghui's biggest competitor was Haiwei Jewelry¹, mainly because their design styles were novel each year, and they kept surpassing themselves every year.

In today's society where a hundred flowers bloom, being able to maintain such strong creativity year after year was a rare thing.

Haiwei Jewelry's main designer was very mysterious, never appearing in public, never participating in any design competitions. Each year's signature was only one letter: Q.

Even the internal employees at Haiwei Jewelry didn't know who Q was.

After all, this person worked from home.

This mysterious designer had caused quite a stir in the industry. Some said it was Su Yao, who had once been at the height of fame but disappeared during her peak years. Others said it was a gifted person with social anxiety. Still others claimed it was the famous designer Cen Jing, who had withdrawn from the design world due to depression.

In any case, there were various theories, none of them reliable.

The media had also tried to investigate, but General Manager Su of Haiwei Jewelry protected this person extremely well.

They couldn't dig up any information at all.

However, most people leaned toward it being Su Yao.

After all—they both had the surname Su.

But some also said that Su Yao had died of grief not long after her boyfriend Sheng Qinglin died in a car accident back then.

The rumors were mixed with truth and falsehood, and Xu Qingzhu didn't know what to believe.

Even though one of her uncles whom she'd never met was involved in this gossip.

Some people even said she wasn't her parents' biological daughter.

People in this circle loved to gossip. Everyone's business could be discussed and spread around seven or eight times, causing these stories to lose their original truth.

Xu Qingzhu had never believed any of it anyway.

She and Xu Qingya looked so much alike.

And her parents treated her extremely well.

She had also seen photos of her uncle at home - he was very handsome, much better looking than current male celebrities.

He resembled her mother by seventy percent, but with more masculine features.

A genius youth who died young.

Xu Qingzhu had also felt sorry for him. When she was little and went with her parents to visit his grave, looking at his photo, her mother would always cry endlessly.

She didn't feel much.

Probably because they had never spent time together.

However, Haiwei Jewelry wasn't just special in design style - their choice of materials and yearly marketing were also excellent.

For a company to reach the position of industry leader, it must have advantages in all aspects.

Xu Qingzhu browsed at the specialty counters for a long time, looking at several stores. After finishing, she went to the restroom, planning to leave the mall and go home.

But as soon as she came out of the restroom, she felt a gust of wind pass by her, and her shoulder hurt.

A man had grabbed the bag from her shoulder and ran off.

In broad daylight...

Robbery...

Xu Qingzhu felt like she might not have checked the almanac before leaving home today.

And it also fulfilled that saying: "Good fortune never comes in pairs, misfortune never comes alone."²

She shouted while chasing: "Robbery!"

And rolled up her sleeves to chase after the person.

That person might have practiced sprinting - he was extremely fast, like a cheetah. When people were caught off guard, he directly knocked through the crowd, weaving through the masses with ease, racing toward the entrance.

A crowd of people were all stunned, no one helped chase, and no one even tried to block him.

Xu Qingzhu shouted loudly: "That person is a robber!"

She had no talent in sports - during school, her physical tests had almost never passed. There was no way she could catch up, so she took out her phone to call the police.

But then a little girl in a lolita dress³ appeared. When the man was almost at the entrance, as he passed by her, the little girl stuck out her foot in red leather shoes and directly tripped the man.

Then the security guards at the entrance finally reacted, and three or five people rushed up to pin the man to the ground.

When Xu Qingzhu arrived, the girl in the lolita dress was holding her bag, looking down at her phone, and without even raising her head said: "Here, check if anything's missing inside."

Xu Qingzhu was panting from running, casually checked through her bag - nothing was missing.

She was particularly puzzled and walked over to ask the pinned man: "What were you thinking? In such a big mall, did you think you could actually escape?"

The man was quite stubborn and turned his head away, ignoring her.

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

An onlooker had called the police. When the police arrived and saw this person, they discovered he was a repeat offender.

After taking Xu Qingzhu's statement and confirming a few details, they took the man away, and this farce finally came to an end.

Xu Qingzhu thanked the little girl: "Thank you."

She took out five hundred yuan from her wallet and handed it over.

The little girl waved her hand to refuse, finally willing to lift her head from her mobile game, looked up and said in surprise: "Xu... Xu Qingzhu?"

Xu Qingzhu also felt the little girl looked familiar but couldn't remember where she'd seen her.

It wasn't until she introduced herself: "Hello, I'm Su Meiqi. I met you before when I was with Lin Xingcan."

"With... together?" Xu Qingzhu was surprised.

"We were friends," Su Meiqi also realized her wording was misleading and immediately corrected herself, "We used to be friends."

This statement made people can't help but ask: "What about now?"

Su Meiqi paused: "We broke off our friendship."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She looked at Su Meiqi, feeling quite a sense of "fellow sufferers," so she asked: "Would you like me to treat you to some orange juice?"

Su Meiqi put away her phone: "Sure."

Footnotes:

¹ Haiwei Jewelry: A fictional high-end jewelry company name (海薇珠宝)

² "Good fortune never comes in pairs, misfortune never comes alone": A Chinese idiom meaning that good things rarely happen together, but bad things often come one after another

³ Lolita dress: A fashion style originating from Japan, characterized by elaborate, doll-like dresses with frills and bows

Chapter 43-4

There was a beverage shop on the first floor of the mall. Xu Qingzhu ordered an orange juice for her and a lemon water for herself.

The two didn't know each other, so naturally they didn't have much to talk about.

However, Su Meiqi was naturally outgoing. She asked Xu Qingzhu very directly, "Are you trying to get information out of me?"

Xu Qingzhu: "...No."

Su Meiqi: "If you ask me about things between me and Lin Xingcan, I can't tell you. But if you're treating me to orange juice to thank me, I think I can drink it."

Xu Qingzhu laughed, "Then drink it, I am thanking you."

Su Meiqi's makeup was very delicate, and she was as pretty as a doll.

She drank orange juice very quickly, gulping it down. In just a few minutes, one cup was already empty.

While Xu Qingzhu had only drunk one-third of hers. She was surprised by the other's speed, but very politely asked, "Do you need another cup?"

Su Meiqi looked at the long queue at the counter, then at her own stomach, and shook her head: "Never mind."

Xu Qingzhu was never good at handling such situations, so naturally the atmosphere became cold.

But Su Meiqi kept stealing glances at her from time to time, looking like she wanted to say something but hesitated.

After several times, Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but ask: "Do you have something you want to tell me?"

Su Meiqi immediately answered: "No."

After answering, she sighed again, "Actually, yes."

Xu Qingzhu: "...?"

"But I don't know if I should say it." Su Meiqi pressed her temples, "It's about your wife Liang Shi. Do you know?"

Xu Qingzhu: "What about it?"

"Don't you think she's different from before? I heard she used to live it up, often hanging around with Cheng Ran." Su Meiqi said, "Lin Xingcan used to cry about these things often."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She seemed to know a bit about that too.

"What happened?" Xu Qingzhu asked calmly, but her eyes revealed curiosity.

The more she acted like this, the more Su Meiqi couldn't hold it in.

For this type of young girl, Xu Qingzhu had already developed the ability to "lure" information from practicing on Xu Qingya.

Sure enough, Su Meiqi was conflicted and hesitant, hesitant and conflicted.

In the end, she still couldn't help it: "After we met last time, Lin Xingcan went to find Liang Shi's mother but didn't get any answers, so she went to investigate on her own."

"And then?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Su Meiqi: "..."

She suddenly knocked her head on the table, "Woow. Sister, I can't say it."

Xu Qingzhu guided her patiently, "Why not?"

"Forget it, you should go ask at Yunyin Taoist Temple¹." Su Meiqi said, "Anyway, it seems to be related to that place. I'm not sure, but Lin Xingcan said it's like someone switched souls with your wife."

Xu Qingzhu: "...?!!"

"I don't really believe in science, but I don't believe in superstitious stuff either." Su Meiqi said, "But Lin Xingcan spoke with such conviction, and said other families had done it before too."

Xu Qingzhu immediately asked: "Where did you say to ask?"

"Yunyin Taoist Temple." Su Meiqi sighed, "The one on Yunfeng Mountain². Sister, I don't believe in this stuff. Do you?"

Xu Qingzhu was silent for a few seconds. Her physics knowledge and scientific theories wavered, and finally she said slowly: "It's better to believe it exists than to believe it doesn't."³

Footnotes:

¹ Yunyin Taoist Temple: 云隐道观 - A fictional Taoist temple name meaning "Cloud-Hidden Taoist Temple"

² Yunfeng Mountain: 云峰山 - A fictional mountain name meaning "Cloud Peak Mountain"

³ "It's better to believe it exists than to believe it doesn't": A Chinese saying expressing the idea that it's safer to believe in something's existence rather than dismiss it entirely, especially regarding supernatural or uncertain matters

Chapter 43-5

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There was less than half a day left of the holiday.

Xu Qingzhu was too eager to figure out the truth, so halfway through her chat with Su Meiqi, she decided to drive up to Yunfeng Mountain.

Before going, she invited Su Meiqi. Although Su Meiqi didn't really want to go, she couldn't resist her inner curiosity.

She got in the car with Xu Qingzhu.

After she got in and fastened her seatbelt, Xu Qingzhu said, "Aren't you afraid I might be a bad person?"

Su Meiqi glanced at her, "I'm an Alpha, you're an Omega. You can't beat me."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She hadn't expected that.

"But I feel a sense of kinship when I see you." Su Meiqi said, "Maybe it's because I like pretty older sisters."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

But she didn't dislike Su Meiqi either.

Even though the other had been friends with Lin Xingcan before.

Probably because Su Meiqi looked harmless and had a straightforward personality.

Yunfeng Mountain was in the suburbs, about an hour's drive away.

Xu Qingzhu had smooth traffic all the way. During the journey, Su Meiqi sporadically gave her some additional information.

Su Meiqi was in a state of "I want to tell you, but I can't tell you too much."

She'd say a few things from time to time, then cut herself off.

Xu Qingzhu just listened.

She didn't press too hard.

After all, Su Meiqi was still preserving the last bit of dignity for her already deceased friendship.

When they reached the foot of Yunfeng Mountain, Su Meiqi began hesitating again about whether to climb the mountain.

She didn't want to climb, but seeing Xu Qingzhu going up alone, she couldn't bear it.

So she reluctantly accompanied Xu Qingzhu, dragging her feet.

As an Alpha, Su Meiqi had a natural advantage and better stamina than Xu Qingzhu when it came to mountain climbing.

After climbing for not long, Xu Qingzhu asked with some despair, "Isn't there a cable car?"

"People who come to pray and worship Buddha would practically crawl up on their knees." Su Meiqi was also tired, breathing a bit heavily, "How could there possibly be a cable car?"

Two desperate people climbed up together.

There weren't many people still going up the mountain at this time - most were coming down.

They passed countless people and finally reached Yunyin Taoist Temple.

When Su Meiqi saw the four characters on the plaque¹, she sighed, "I've used up a year's worth of exercise."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

So had she.

But Xu Qingzhu cared about face and didn't say so.

Just as Xu Qingzhu was about to enter the temple, she ran into a group of people coming out.

One of the girls looked very familiar - she was Liang Shi's colleague.

Obviously, the other person also recognized her and, after a moment of surprise, gave her a brilliant smile.

Xu Qingzhu nodded to her, but her heart sank to the bottom.

Liang Shi had said she was going out with colleagues today - had she come to Yunyin Taoist Temple?

But Liang Shi wasn't among that group of people.

The other girls who were with Li Ran also recognized Xu Qingzhu and were whispering among themselves.

"Wow, I thought she was pretty enough on camera, but she's even more beautiful in real life."

"Beautiful women are so easy on the eyes."

"The little girl next to her is as delicate as a doll, and she looks a bit like her."

"How do they look alike? Their temperaments are completely different."

"The eyes."

"..."

They discussed in low voices. Li Ran looked in another direction and saw Liang Shi jogging over, carrying a bag of water, distributing it to everyone.

When she got to Li Ran, Li Ran frantically gestured with her eyes.

But Liang Shi asked, "Sister Ran, what's wrong with your eyes?"

Li Ran: "..."

She said directly, "Look over there."

Liang Shi followed her gaze and unexpectedly made eye contact with Xu Qingzhu.

...

The air was silent for a few seconds.

Li Ran happened to ask, "Did your wife come to pick you up and take you home?"

Liang Shi: "..."

That definitely wasn't it.

Footnotes:

¹ Four characters on the plaque: Referring to the temple name "云隐道观" (Yunyin Taoist Temple) written in traditional Chinese characters on the entrance plaque

Chapter 43-6

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Since they had encountered Liang Shi, Xu Qingzhu and Su Meiqi directly turned around and went back with them.

Going up the mountain had been exhausting to death, but going down was easy and relaxed.

No matter how tactless Su Meiqi was or how curious she was about Liang Shi, she was too embarrassed to wedge herself between the married couple, so she simply walked together with Liang Shi's colleagues.

With her cheerful personality, she quickly hit it off with them.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi's other colleagues were still in shock - actually!

The young lady of Minghui Jewelry was Little Liang's wife!

Then they belatedly realized - Little Liang was the third young miss of the Liang family!

Oh, it must be because Little Liang was so approachable that they had forgotten.

The colleagues were trapped in their shock and unable to extricate themselves. After the silence, they began discussing frantically.

But the atmosphere between the two people lagging behind was a bit heavy.

Xu Qingzhu still hadn't asked anything.

Liang Shi was thinking about how to explain.

"I heard from Su Meiqi," Xu Qingzhu spoke first, "your personality change is related to Yunyin Taoist Temple. It's because of some mystical arts¹ here that caused your change, right?"

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, looked at the people coming and going around them, and thought: "How about we talk about it when we get home?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She didn't bring up the matter again.

After going down the mountain, it was Liang Shi who drove. She first sent Su Meiqi home.

In the car, Su Meiqi kept staring at her. Finally, just before getting out, she asked a question: "Sisters, what do you think is more likely - transmigrating into a book or TV drama, or a Taoist priest successfully changing fate and switching souls?"

Liang Shi's foot slipped on the gas pedal and she almost crashed the car by the roadside.

Xu Qingzhu seriously considered before answering: "In the first half of my life, both of these possibilities were zero."

Su Meiqi was deflated: "Why don't you believe in book transmigration?"

The chuunibyou² beautiful girl explained it this way: "In this vast universe, there must be parallel universes and parallel worlds! A person going to another world is just crossing parallel worlds, right? This is similar to the principles of wormholes and time travel."

Feeling she couldn't convince Xu Qingzhu, she turned to Liang Shi seeking agreement: "Sister Liang, what do you think?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She now felt that - anything was possible.

But she couldn't say that, so she hedged: "It depends on how scientists define it. Who knows, maybe millions of years from now, humans will be living together with extraterrestrial beings."

Su Meiqi: "..."

Not getting the answer she wanted, Su Meiqi left like a deflated ball, looking dejected.

With only the two of them left in the car, Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes to rest.

When they got home, Xu Qingzhu changed her shoes at the entrance, took off her gray coat and hung it by the door, then walked directly to sit on the sofa. Liang Shi did the same.

Liang Shi was considering how to begin. During her silence, Xu Qingzhu said: "Haven't figured out how to make something up yet?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Or how to lie to me." Xu Qingzhu said it directly: "Are you suffering from amnesia or soul-switching? Why did you go to Yunyin Taoist Temple?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her temples, sat on the sofa, her tone lazy as she said in a completely non-aggressive manner: "You can choose to stay silent, I won't ask again. But if you want to speak, then tell the truth. I don't want to hear lies you've painstakingly made up - it's meaningless."

Liang Shi: "..."

The house was so quiet you could hear a pin drop, the atmosphere at a standstill.

After a long silence, Liang Shi spoke: "I went to Yunyin Taoist Temple to investigate that photo."

She didn't answer about the soul-switching matter - answering poorly could easily get her taken to some mysterious organization for dissection.

She only picked what she could answer: "Didn't you also see it that day? In that photo on my phone, that ritual was conducted by people from Yunyin Taoist Temple, and I was a sacrificial offering."

"So I wanted to go and figure out that matter." Liang Shi said: "In the Liang family, someone wants to harm me. And my personality change should be related to this, but I really have forgotten many things, so I can't tell you."

[Ding dong! Congratulations host, your luck value has accumulated to sixty, triggering passive mission: Go to a concert with Xu Qingzhu. PS: Concerts can cultivate one's temperament, especially in dim environments, it's easier for ambiguity to grow! Another PS: Pay attention to environmental protection, don't bring your own drinks and popcorn.]

Liang Shi: "..."

Couldn't you wait until she finished speaking before coming?!

Footnotes:

¹ Mystical arts: 玄黄之术 - referring to ancient Chinese occult practices and divination arts

² Chuunibyou: A Japanese term for "eighth-grader syndrome," referring to someone who acts like they're in their own fantasy world, often used to describe overly dramatic or imaginative teenage behavior